NFL Showdown: Playing Like a Pro

CODY MAIN // SEP 7, 2026

In Part 1 of this series, we established two things: The post-lock sims are well calibrated at the cash-rate and top-1% level, and max-entry players systematically outperform every other cohort on virtually any metric we can measure with the post-lock sim data at our disposal. They have a higher average sim ROI, higher cash rate, higher top-1% rate, and higher actual ROI, and the gap isn't particularly close.

We determined in Part 1 whether the sims work and tried to understand where there may be flaws. In Part 2, we're going to attempt to understand what the "pros" are doing so we can leverage that information in our lineup-building process.

The important distinction to make here is that we aren't going to focus on what or who won. The Solver's post-lock sim data only dates back to Week 5 of the 2025 season and gives us a 33-slate sample to draw from. While it's a growing sample, it's still too noisy to learn much from, given how much a single slate can distort everything. Instead, we're going to focus on the subset of players who simply build better lineups than their opponents and ask what they're doing differently. While single lineup decisions will be a component of this article, the more important question to answer is how the best players are thinking about constructing a portfolio of lineups with the goal of growing their bankroll.

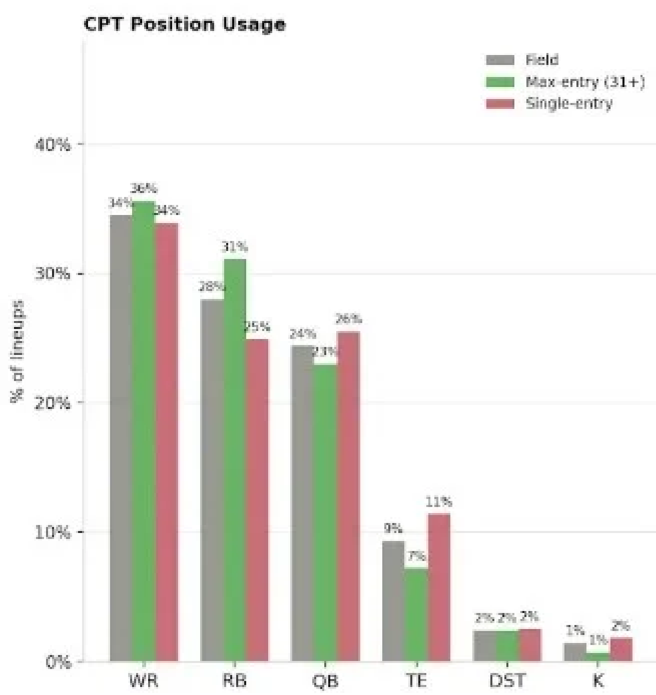
How Pros Build

Before we get into the specifics, it's worth repeating that this analysis is focused on NFL primetime showdown slates from Week 5 through the Super Bowl of the 2025 season, spanning 33 slates. For those 33 slates, we've gathered the post-lock sim data from The Solver for the Wildcat or Field

General contests, which are generally between 1,000 and 1,500 total entries with a 37-entry max per user at either a $333 or $444 buy-in.

To highlight the skill gap we're working with, max-entry (31+ entries in a slate) players averaged +12.0% sim ROI per lineup across our dataset, while players who submitted just a single lineup in those same contests averaged -10.5%. Cash rate (23.1% vs. 21.1%), top-1% rate (1.37% vs. 0.92%), and actual ROI (+8.0% vs. -21.6%) were just as drastic. So what are max-entry players doing at the lineup level that leads to such drastic differences in results?

CPT Selection



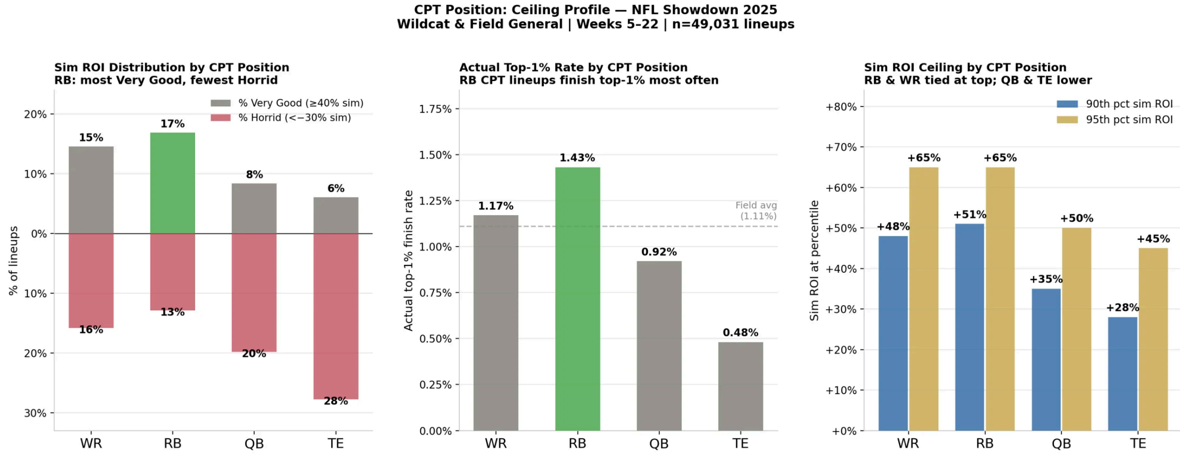
This isn't our first time reviewing the proper CPT allocation. We've reviewed it over multiple seasons in lottery-style contests on DraftKings; we've looked at what top-1% finishing lineups do most often; and we've looked at what the field is doing to try and identify how we can give ourselves the biggest advantage at the format's most important roster spot.

Max-entry players use CPT RB in 31.1% of their lineups compared to 24.9% from single-entry players. Max-entry CPT RB lineups average a +8.0% sim ROI, CPT WR +4.5%, CPT QB -3.3%, and CPT TE -12.0%, highlighting an advantage gained over the field simply by dedicating a higher percentage of their lineups to the running back position. Additionally, max-entry players use CPT TE just 7.2% of the time versus 11.4% for single-entry players.

Over the 33 slates in our sample, the actual results followed the sim's expectations. Across all lineups, CPT RB averaged a +24.8% actual ROI, 24.7% cash rate, and 1.43% top-1% rate, while CPT TE lineups posted a -53.0% actual ROI. Among max-entry players only, CPT RB lineups averaged a +54.7% actual ROI and 1.77% top-1% rate. While those results are merely descriptive and can be heavily influenced by a few outcomes over a relatively small sample, the consistency with what was expected by the sim ROI provides some validation. CPT RB is more consistently assigned a positive post-lock sim ROI and is more frequently used by max-entry players than their lower-volume counterparts. So why do the sims like CPT RB?

The answer is nuanced, but we can make some assumptions from our 33-slate sample without seeing a player-level distribution under the hood. Of the slates we tracked, running backs were the only position to outperform their ETR projection on average, scoring 0.2 DraftKings points more than projected, with a 45% beat rate, compared to wide receivers, who underperformed by 1.5 DraftKings points, and tight ends, who scored 3.1 points fewer on average, beating their projection just 30% of the time. The implication is that RBs are more likely to beat their mean projection.

CPT RB lineups don't just produce a better average sim ROI; they also produce a better distribution of lineups. CPT RB lineups hit the Very Good threshold (>= 40% sim ROI) at the highest rate of any position (16.9%) and had the lowest Horrid rate (< -30%) at 12.9%. CPT TE, for example, hit Very Good just 6.1% of the time and found the Horrid bucket at a 27.8% clip.



The most important finding might be the construction trigger and compounding effect that CPT RB funnels lineups toward. CPT RB includes D/ST in FLEX at the highest rate of any position (17.8%). Of course, pairing CPT RB with same-team D/ST naturally correlates around a specific game-script bet. If our RB beats his mean projection, there's an increased chance the game is playing out as expected and his team's D/ST is also scoring well. CPT RB also correlates with higher utilization of five-favorite, one-underdog constructions (19.0%) and fewer three-favorite, three-underdog (29.0%) builds, compared to other positions. CPT RB creates a natural pull toward unbalanced builds, which result in a higher average sim ROI. When you combine these three elements: CPT RB + same-team D/ST + 5-1 roster construction, average sim ROI jumps to 24.6% with a 27.5% Very Good rate and just a 3.5% Horrid rate.

We know by now that max-entry players outperform single-entry players in every single metric. That holds true when we look at how they deploy the CPT position on an ownership basis. That means the ownership bucket(s) max-entry players most often utilize aren't the primary driver of better lineups; rather, the decision-making process is better throughout the entire lineup.

We did, however, find that single-entry players are over-indexing heavily in the sub-5% CPT ownership range (25.4% utilization vs. 16.3% for max-entry players), chasing low-owned captains with an even worse likelihood of achieving a slate-winning score. Max-entry players allocated their CPT exposure more evenly across the 5-25% implied ownership range, where the sim most consistently assigns a positive ROI across all cohorts. While max-entry players still found a positive average sim ROI (+5%) when using sub-5%-owned CPTs, it was the lowest average ROI among all implied ownership buckets. Similarly, while single-entry players posted a negative average sim ROI across all implied CPT ownership buckets, their best results (-3%) came from the 25+% range. This isn't to suggest we shouldn't roster a low-owned CPT; max-entry players allocate 16% of their portfolios to the sub-5% range too. We just shouldn't solely use low ownership as a reason to play them.

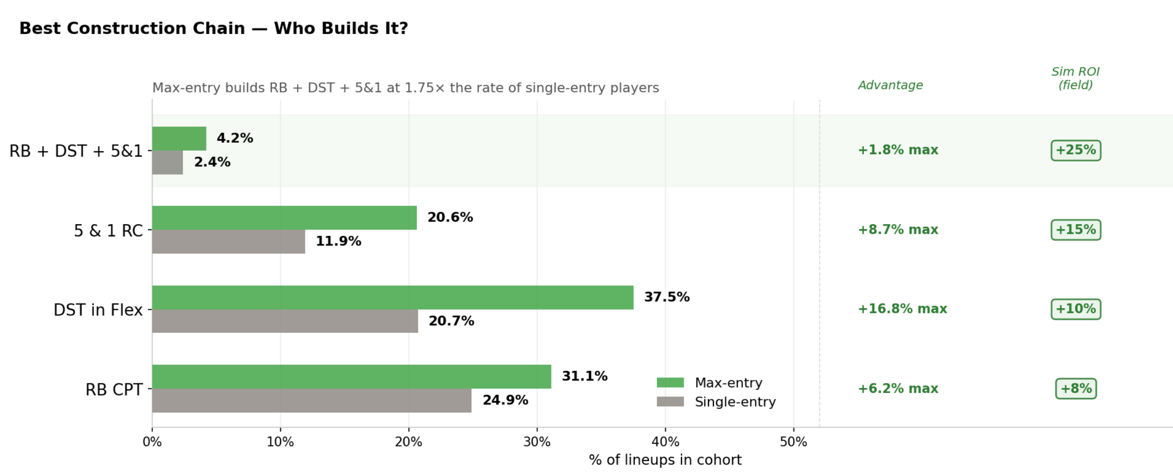
Roster Construction

Understanding team-level roster construction has become table stakes in NFL showdown, to the point where we project how many players from each team the field will use on each slate. In our *Showdown Breakdown* column, you'll find utilization projections for each of the possible combinations: 5 (favorites) – 1 (underdog), 4-2, 3-3, 2-4, and 1-5. Each construction represents an implied bet on how the game is going to play out. 5-1 suggests the favorite will dominate, 3-3 might assume a more back-and-forth affair, and 1-5 paints a picture of an underdog not only covering the spread but winning outright.

Based on the 33-slate sample we have from last season, the sim's verdict on 3-3 roster construction is fairly clear, owning the lowest average sim ROI (-4.9%) of any roster construction, and yet single-entry players utilized it at a 38.0% clip versus 26.8% for max-entry players. I don't think that gap is a coincidence, but instead a difference in each cohort's understanding of game-script uncertainty.

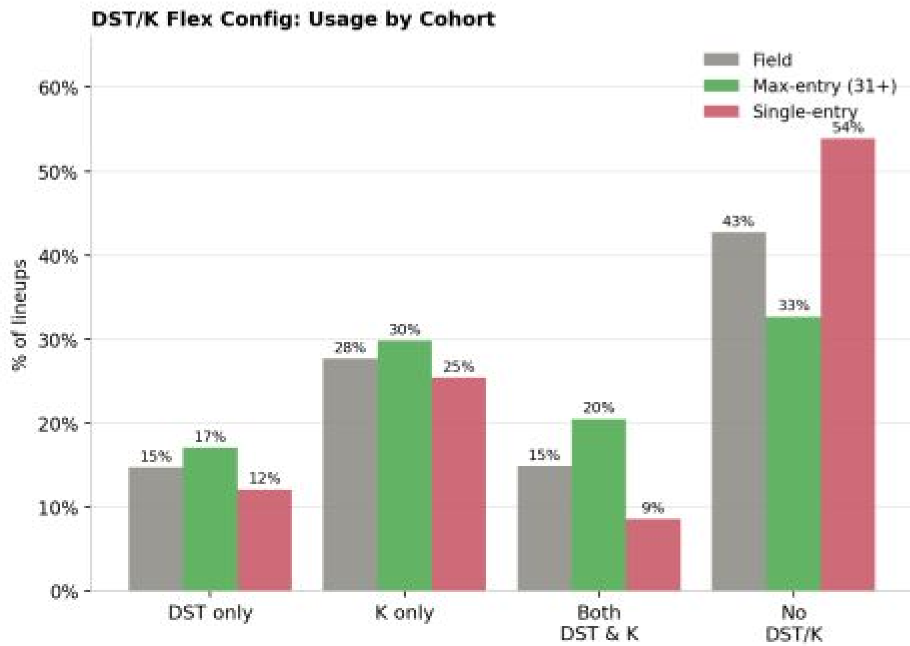
3-3 builds become a low-conviction default for users submitting single lineups as a means to structure a lineup around a balanced game script that doesn't properly account for the inherently volatile outcomes in a single NFL game. That doesn't mean max-entry players are avoiding 3-3 builds entirely either, but they are more willing than single-entry users to play for outcomes that attempt to capture the necessary real-life right-tail outcomes required to climb DFS leaderboards.

Max-entry players used 5-1 roster constructions (20.6%) far more than single-entry players (11.9%), averaging a +20.2% sim ROI, a 24.2% Very Good rate, and just a 5.2% Horrid rate. These lineups are often structured around a coherent game script that positions them to succeed when that game script comes to fruition and fail when it doesn't. An even more drastic example of this is the opposite construction: max-entry players deploying 1-5 builds at an 8.5% clip vs. 3.3% for single-entry players. It's the type of low-probability bet that can produce asymmetric upside when it hits, fitting into **Drew Dinkmeyer**'s old adage of "what do you win, when you win?"



DST/K In FLEX

Look, I'm like most of you; I *want* to root for receptions, yards, and touchdowns in primetime island games. Watching a 9-3 Jets vs. Browns showdown snoozer isn't my Thursday night cup of tea. It's clear, however, that there is a distinct behavioral gap between single-entry and max-entry players that follows that exact logic.



Single-entry players run no D/ST or K in FLEX in 53.9% of their lineups, producing a -17.2% average sim ROI and -32% actual ROI. Max-entry players deploy lineups with no D/ST or K in just 32.7% of their lineups, but even those versions are better positioned for success (+5.6% sim ROI). It is still their weakest lineup configuration by a wide margin, even if overall structure and decision-making make this subset a +EV bet on average.

The decisions are even more pronounced when looking at *just* lineups that include both D/ST and K, with max-entry players using this construction in 20.5% of their lineups for an average +16.9% sim ROI and 1.87% top-1% rate compared to single-entry players who use this build in just 8.6% of their lineups. For the same reasons single-entry players over-index on 3-3 builds, double D/ST and K builds get overlooked because it forces conviction on a specific game script that most users hand-building a single lineup aren't willing to commit to.

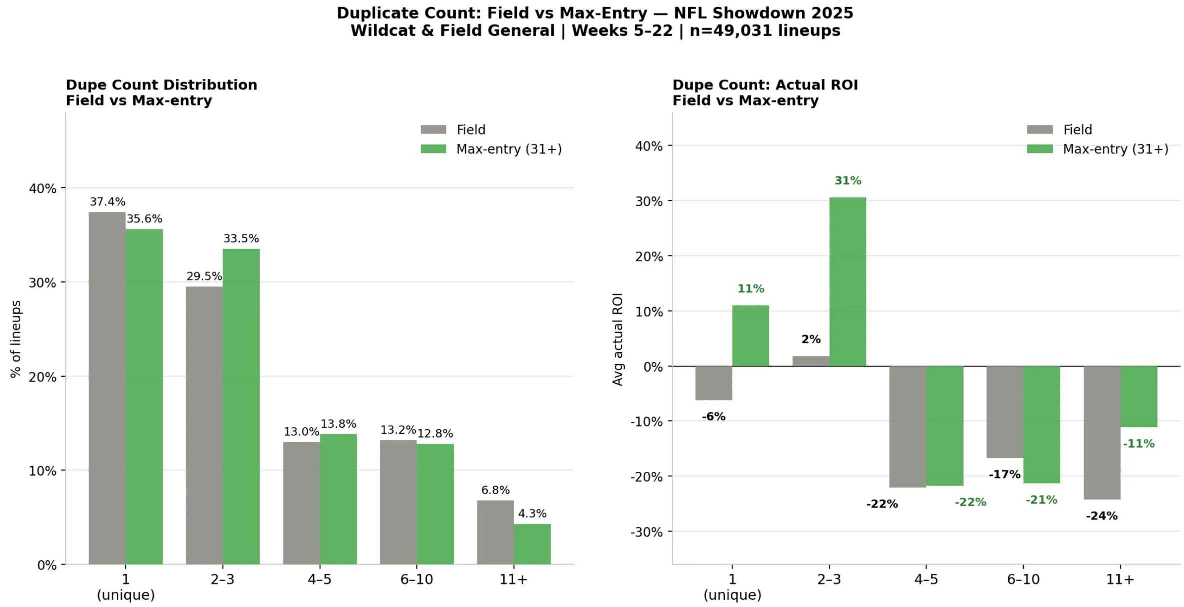
This isn't to suggest all lineups should contain a kicker, D/ST, or multiples of either, but before submitting any showdown lineups, it's worth asking yourself whether rostering six skill players is a deliberate decision you want to make or whether it's a default you landed on, because the sim is often going to penalize it.

Dupe Counts

It's worth being honest about what we can and can't control pre-lock, particularly regarding projected duplicates. The best pre-lock predictors of dupe count are still variables that have an overall weak correlation to actual dupes, but using them along with the displayed dupe count in The Solver's sims can help paint a picture of how often we should expect other users to play any given lineup.

Product ownership, the measurement that multiplies the ownership of every player in the lineup, correlated with dupe count at r = +0.430; cumulative ownership, the sum of all players' ownership, at r = +0.390; and relative projection, how close the lineup's total ETR projection is to the theoretical maximum for a given slate, at r = +0.384.

The logic between all three is fairly similar: Lineups get duplicated because multiple players using the same projection systems arrive at the same players or lineups, and highly-projected lineups are likelier to feature highly-owned players that will converge with the rest of the field.



Using the relative projection percentile and projected cumulative ownership, we can get a reasonable gauge of how popular a given lineup might be. A lineup with 200+% cumulative ownership that projects in the top 1% of the slate averaged 15 dupes in this dataset, with a 90th-percentile outcome of 42. For comparison, a lineup in the top 2-5% and 180-200% cumulative ownership averages four dupes and a 90th-percentile outcome of 11. Max-entry players assign 53.7% of their lineups to the 90-95% of slate-max projection range vs. 41.8% for single-entry users, where the sim still provides a strong positive ROI without running into the same dupe effects that higher-projecting lineups face.

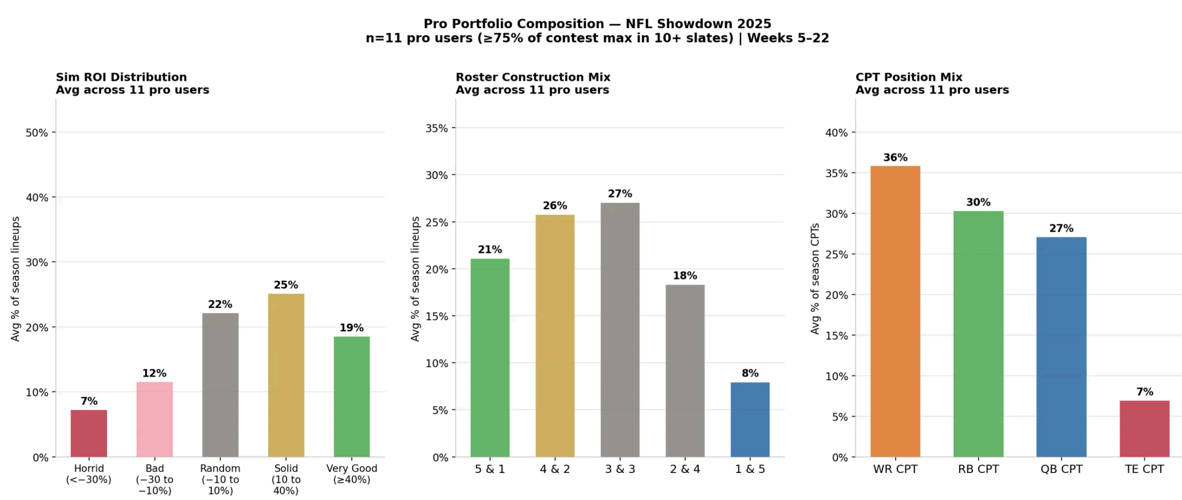
How Pros Diversify

The goal of this article isn't to convince you to enter 44 lineups in the $333 Wildcat because we know what max-entry players are doing. Not everyone has the bankroll for that. The point is that the players who consistently grow their bankrolls in these contests aren't just doing it through better individual lineup decisions; they're also thinking about their entries as an entire portfolio. Whether you're entering three lineups or 44, or considering a different contest entirely, the same portfolio logic applies, even if you have fewer bullets or less money in play.

A reminder: We defined "pros" as players who entered at least 75% of the contest maximum on 10 or more slates across the 2025 season that we have data for. This gave us consistent, high-volume participation to analyze in an 11-player cohort.

Nine of the 11 players were profitable over a 33-slate sample, a meaningful number given that only 14% of all qualified users in our dataset made money. One of the two max-entry users who did not make money during this 33-slate sample averaged the highest sim ROI of any user in the dataset at +24.9%, a harsh reality check that even if you're building better individual lineups than the rest of the field, there is no guarantee of actual profit, particularly in what is still a relatively small sample.

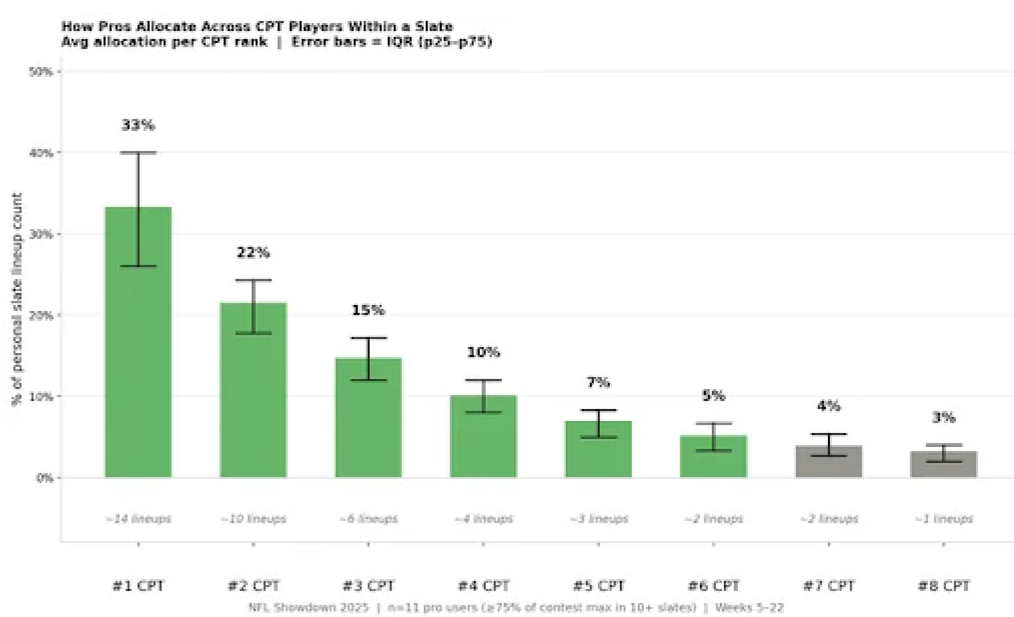
What the Portfolio Actually Looks Like



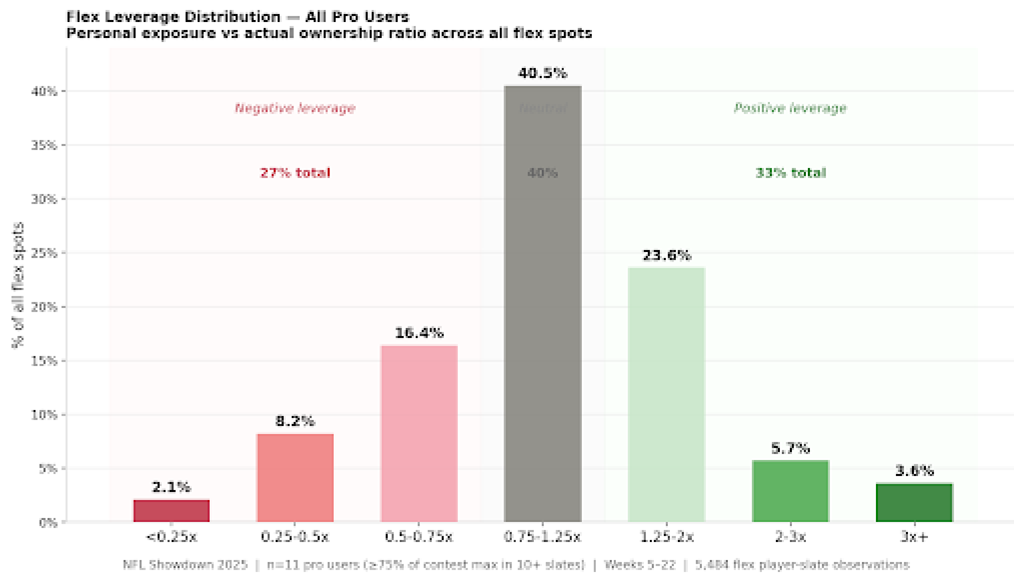
Across the 11 users we tracked, the season-long portfolio had a few defining characteristics that we can apply to our allocations.

The sim ROI distribution shows that about 19% of these users' lineups qualified as Very Good (>= 40% sim ROI), another 25% are Solid (10-40%), and only 7% qualified as Horrid (< -30%), while single-entry users submitted Horrid lineups at a 28% clip. The goal wasn't to *only* submit the very best lineups but rather to find a group of lineups that were *not* bad.

A similar logic can be applied to game-script construction. Max-entry players used 5-1 at 21%, 4-2 at 26%, 3-3 at 27%, 2-4 at 18%, and 1-5 at 8%. They weren't over-indexing on a specific game script, but instead covering the full distribution of how games can actually play out. Even their usage of 3-3 construction shows they aren't avoiding particular builds.



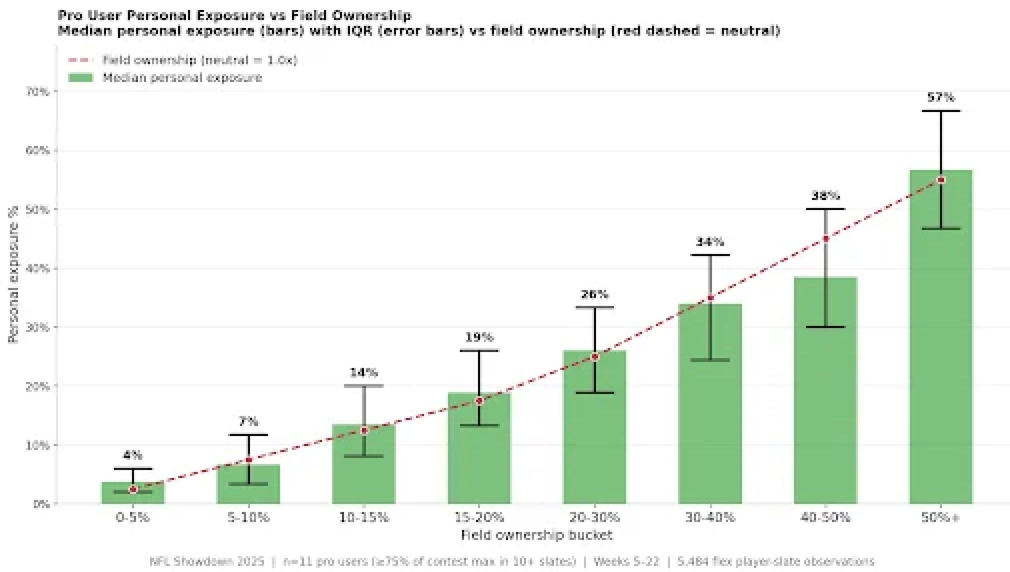
One of the most common portfolio-driven questions I get is "how many captains should I play in 'X' contest?" and it often elicits a non-answer that asks the inquirer to consider their own risk tolerance, level of conviction, etc. But analyzing max-entry players' CPT portfolio in the Wildcat may provide better insight into how these players think through this question. From the 33-slate sample we looked at, max-entry players averaged 8.7 unique CPT players per slate across their portfolio, ranging from 6.9 to 11.4 per user. On average, the most-owned CPT received 33% exposure, second-most-owned CPT 22%, third 15%, fourth 10%, fifth 7%, sixth 5%, seventh 4%, and eighth 3%.



A common belief is that high-volume players are constantly taking aggressive stands against the field by fading chalk and loading up on low-owned dart throws as a means to ladder up DFS leaderboards, and they're able to do so because they have more bullets and a bigger bankroll to take extremely leveraged positions.

We measured leverage by comparing each max-entry user's personal exposure to each FLEX spot against that FLEX spot's actual ownership in the contest. A FLEX player who is owned by 40% of the field and appears in 60% of a max-entry user's portfolio represents a 1.5x positive leverage play. The same player at 20% exposure in their portfolio would represent a 0.5x negative leverage position.

From the chart above, we can see that 40.5% of all FLEX roster spots fell within the 0.75-1.25x range, meaning that a FLEX player who was owned by 40% of the field was owned by max-entry users somewhere between 30% and 50%. The vast majority of their FLEX decisions were not full fades or massive overweight positions.



This chart depicts a similar story, showing the median personal exposure by max-entry users, bucketed by each FLEX player's actual ownership across the entire field. The red dashed line shows a neutral position relative to the field; anywhere the green bar sits above the red line indicates a spot where the max-entry users are overweight, and anywhere below the red line is underweight.

We can see that max-entry users are willing to take more shots on sub-5%-owned FLEX players, rostering them at a 4% clip, representing a +1.85x leveraged position against the field, and modestly underweight FLEX options that land in the 5-10% range, where players may not be low-owned enough to justify the drop in projection and too owned to meaningfully improve the reduction in projected dupes.

Putting It Together

The skill gap between max-entry and single-entry players in these contests can't be summarized by a single thing; instead, it's a collection of small construction advantages that accumulate across all lineups and dozens of separate slates, resulting in an edge that consistently allows them to maximize bankroll growth. When these decisions are compounded, they produce a +12.0% average sim ROI for max-entry users vs. -10.5% for their single-entry peers.

Though we may not be able to replicate their success at the same stakes, we can apply many of these findings in other contests to increase our expected value. Some practical questions we can ask ourselves before we submit a single lineup or a full portfolio: Would a max-entry player recognize why this lineup is built this way? Is there a clear game-script decision behind the CPT choice? Does the roster construction of this lineup match the bet I'm making on the game? Is there a D/ST or K in FLEX, or is it missing for a reason? Is the fantasy-point projection of this lineup competitive without being amongst the most obvious builds on the slate? Am I aware of where my CPT and FLEX positions stand relative to projected field ownership, and are those positions intentional?

We can't guarantee profit, but if we're able to answer these questions each slate, we're building in a way that aligns with the way the best players build, and just maybe our post-lock expectations will be closer to +12% than -10% as a result.

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